

Identity, ideology and threatening communication

An investigation of patterns of attitude in terrorist discourse

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Linguistic analysis of the interpersonal patterning of threatening communication is a means of uncovering the attitudes, ideological orientation, and hostile intentions of perpetrators of violence in terrorist discourse (Gales 2010, 2011). Corpus analysis focused on attitudinal meaning also offers a diagnostic for characterizing the personal and relational identities (Bednarek 2010) manifest in such texts. This paper explores discursive patterns of authorial identity in terrorist communication in a set of post-9/11 terrorist public statements made by former al-Qaeda leader, Osama bin Laden. It draws on the Appraisal framework (Martin and White 2005), a model of evaluative language developed within Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL), to investigate the interpersonal component in this dataset. Specifically, patterns of ATTITUDE provide evidence of relational and actional attitude, and personal and relational identities. Negative JUDGEMENT was found to characterize the encoded attitude in terms of (i) construing aggression and conflicting moral values (e.g., SOCIAL SANCTION underpinning a perceived personal duty) and (ii) enacting the author's aggressive and aloof identity, and violent actional attitude.

Keywords: aggression, attitudinal meaning, conflict, identity, terrorist discourse

1. Introduction: Attitudinal stance and identity

This paper explores how attitudinal resources operate as discursive markers of personal and relational identity in written terrorist communication, contributing to semantics-based forensic linguistics research into discourses of violence and hate speech (see, e.g., Coulthard et al. 2017; Prideaux 2011; Shuy 2010; Smith and

Shuy 2002). It investigates the types of attitudinal meaning that characterize the relational identities construed in a set of post 9/11 terrorist statements made by al-Qaeda leader, Osama bin Laden. The study is part of a broader project on the discursive practices of incitement and threatening in terrorist public statements – broadly referred to as threatening communication due to encompassing both *threats communicated* to opponents (see, e.g., Gales 2010), and *threats constructed* to mobilize and incite the author's audiences (see, e.g., Cap 2017). Adopting a social semiotic perspective, in conjunction with analytical tools drawn from the Appraisal framework (Martin and White 2005), the present study focuses on discursive patterns of attitude as a way of understanding the identities construed in the specialised corpus of bin Laden's texts. Our approach combines forensic linguistics approaches to authorship detection with the affordances of corpus linguistic methods such as close inspection of concordance lines and frequency information. The aim is to use corpus methods where they serve to illuminate dimensions of meaning that are useful to forensic linguists. We adopt the general theoretical orientation that the ideological struggles of individuals and groups are manifest in the meanings and social values that are contested in the texts they produce (Verschuere 2012, 7–10).

There are many current approaches to identity inside and outside linguistics (see Benwell and Stokoe 2006; Omoniye and White 2006). Within linguistics, approaches vary across (sub)disciplines, such as sociolinguistics, conversation analysis, critical discourse analysis and discursive psychology and include a variety of approaches within domains such as politeness research, performative analysis, narrative analysis, and positioning theory. Some scholars such as Tajfel and Turner (1979), Sacks (1992) and those influenced by Labov, apply a membership category approach that equates identity with group-level categories (e.g., social class and nationality) and treats identity as a stable dimension that shapes the way people use language. Other scholars adopt a social constructionist approach, assuming that identity is forged through social action (e.g., Block 2006; Tracy and Robles 2002). This is a view of identity as inherently fluid; people change their identities to suit momentary needs, and an identity is thus “an accomplishment” (Tracy and Robles 2002, 21).

Block (2006, 38–39) argues that identity types are co-constructed and are simultaneously individual and collective in nature (involving both self-positioning and positioning by others). This approach is echoed in Tracy and Robles's (2002, 21–24) taxonomy of identities that incorporates the following types: *master* (e.g., gender, ethnicity and religion), *interactional* (defining the 'roles' that people take on in a communicative context (e.g., teacher, student, father, employee, leader), and *personal* (e.g., aggressive, tolerant, aloof, friendly). Personal identities have to do with individuals' personality, stances and inter-

personal relationships. They are usually bound up with master and interactional identities via, for example, an in-group's expectations and cultural beliefs (Tracy and Robles 2002, 23) about a Muslim leader's personality attributes and how they ought to act. We argue for Tracy and Robles's contention that personal relationship-linked identities do not exist separate from master and interactional identities since, for example, "[p]ersons in an employee-supervisor relationship ... would be expected to enact an *unequal* relationship at least part of the time" (emphasis added, Tracy and Robles 2002, 23).

In this study, we adopt Tracy and Robles's (2002) concept of identity. The focus is on repeated realizations of attitudinal evaluation to get at what Tracy and Robles (2002) refer to as personal and relational identities (Bednarek 2010, 253–255). Personal identity is what we usually think of as individuals' personality and character (e.g., timid, serious, aggressive). Personal identity also includes the relationships individuals have with others (e.g., superior, subordinate, distant, close), and their attitudes about other people, events, and social issues. In this sense of relating personal identity to one's relationship, personal identity is also termed "relational" identity (Tracy and Robles 2002, 22–23). Examining terrorist acts as forms of aggression, terrorists' attitudinal stances are likely to draw on particular value systems to appraise themselves and their opponents as lower or higher in worth with regard to a set of values, particularly those of aggression, morality, justice and religious values (Smith 2004). They may attitudinally target an aspect of identity through what has been referred to as "identity attacks" (see Culpeper et al. 2017, 22–23).

Our approach to identity factors in dimensions such as the speakers' or writers' stances towards "the entities, happenings, or state of affairs being construed by the text" (White 2015, 44–45) and to people, opinions and behaviours introduced in the text. It accounts for dimensions of terrorist personae such as (in)tolerance, aggression, opposition to or support of particular phenomena, and so forth, through mapping attitudinal meanings, which cannot be tracked by fully automated protocols since computational tools tend to overlook patterns of interpersonal meanings which are difficult to automatically detect and are context-based sensitive (Gozdz-Roszkowski and Hunston 2016; Thompson and Alba-Jues 2014). A terrorist identity is argued to be – using Bednarek's (2010) terms on performing identities – "performatively" produced or constituted by repeated attitudinal expressions.

2. Attitudinal patterning of identity

The current study contributes to the literature on examining language features, indicative criteria and grounds for reasonable suspicion about an author's identity and attitudes (see, e.g., Gales 2010, 2011, 2013, 2015). Terrorist statements, as social acts, are politically motivated and strategically used to advance religious, ethnonationalist, or politico-ideological causes (i.e., leftist or rightist agenda) (see Lutz and Lutz 2008; Malešević 2019; Smith 2004, 2018, 1; Whittaker 2005). Given that evaluative expressions are social acts with their own underpinning sociocultural value systems which target participants and related phenomena (see du Bois 2007; Hunston 1993), we argue that repeated attitudinal expressions are acts of identity (Tabouret-Keller 1997, 315) – exemplified in Subsection 5.2. The significance of investigating personal identities consistently identified in ideological perceptions and encoded in lexical structures lies in revealing which salient identities tend to characterize texts. Particular identities tend to become more salient under stress, conflict, and lack of security (Suleiman 2006).

In her discourse analysis of conflicting ideological perceptions in newspapers covering the South African-Lesotho conflict, Thetela (2001) explored the rhetorical patterns that characterize the ideological perception-semantics illustrated (among other features) through lexical structure. Thetela emphasized the role of lexical selection as an indicator of ideology and a signal of attitudes and ideological perceptions of authors. She also stressed that lexical choice with normative judgement (i.e., which derives from particular social standards on good behaviour) has the ideological function of establishing rival identities and ideologically opposing poles. This lexical selection forms the basis of what we term in this paper the *salient encoded attitude* – salient in the sense that an attitude type (e.g., JUDGEMENT) occurs in repeated attitudinal lexical items across a set of texts at least more than twice as often as any other attitude type (e.g., AFFECT and APPRECIATION, see Section 3). The less frequent types of attitude are then described as non-salient attitude.

There has been limited study of attitudinal stance and identity in terrorist threatening communication and there is much research still to be undertaken (Gales 2010). The present study responds to Gozdz-Roszkowski and Hunston's (2016) call to investigate the supporting role of evaluative (attitudinal) meanings in new areas and genres. While Gales has shown that attitudinal expressions play a key role in the functioning of terrorist communication, a number of areas remain to be empirically verified, including: other roles that functional patterns of attitudinal meanings play within the discourse of terrorist communication, the extent to which such functional patterns exist within a terrorist group's specific statements or across organizations' texts and on what sociocultural values functional

patterns are based. There has also been limited research that attempts to apply simultaneously a *system and structure* approach (i.e., paradigmatic and syntagmatic feature-based approach) and *value parameter-based* approach (see, e.g., Bednarek 2006; Lemke 1992, 1998; Thetela 1997, 2001) to attitude in terrorist communication. This study contributes to filling this gap.

In line with Hasan's (2010, 277–278) view of *encoding* and *decoding* (McMenamin 2010), we view the *encoded attitude* function, whether it is inscribed or invoked (i.e., explicit or implicit), as the one construed by the author as a result of context activation of meaning and meaning activation of wording. We term the outcome of the process in which we (the analysts) are involved as the *decoded attitude*. Providing a functional linguistic account that characterizes an author's encoded attitude in a set of texts, as such, will be based on providing an account of repeated lexical forms, i.e., wording, that construe meaning, and meaning choice then construes context. In this study, we decode attitudes (i.e., we unveil the encoded attitude); we study the patterns of meaning (paradigmatic relations) in repeated lexical structures (syntagmatic relations). We argue that through this functional approach to language we are “investigating how language is used: trying to find out what the purposes that language serves for [authors] are, and how [they] are able to achieve these purposes through [texts]” (Halliday 1973, 7). The functions of language provide the motivations for language form and structure (Halliday 1978). Within SFL, meaning is construed as a function of human experience and is encoded in language around three (meta)functions included in every use of language; the interpersonal (meta)function, which is our focus, serves to enact relationships (Martin and Rose 2003, 6). A contribution in this direction of investigating attitude to getting at the personal and relational identities is likely to establish a link between the author's identity, attitudinal expressions, socioculturally-situated meaning and ideologically and contextually motivated choice of language forms (Gales 2010; Jaffe 2009; Johnstone 2009).

3. Theoretical framework: The appraisal framework

The theoretical framework in which this work is situated is the Appraisal framework (Martin and White 2005), developed within the social semiotic paradigm of Systemic Functional Linguistics. Appraisal offers a discourse semantic approach to evaluative language, modelled as three interacting systems of meaning: *ATTITUDE* which concerns values for construing positive/negative stances, *GRADUATION* which deals with values of grading evaluation and *ENGAGEMENT* which considers how the author engages with other voices (Martin and White 2005, 35–44). This study is primarily concerned with the *ATTITUDE* system and, thus,

with stances toward phenomena. The ATTITUDE system encompasses three simultaneously operating systems: attitude types, explicitness (inscribed or invoked), and polarity (positive attitude or negative attitude) (see Figure 1).

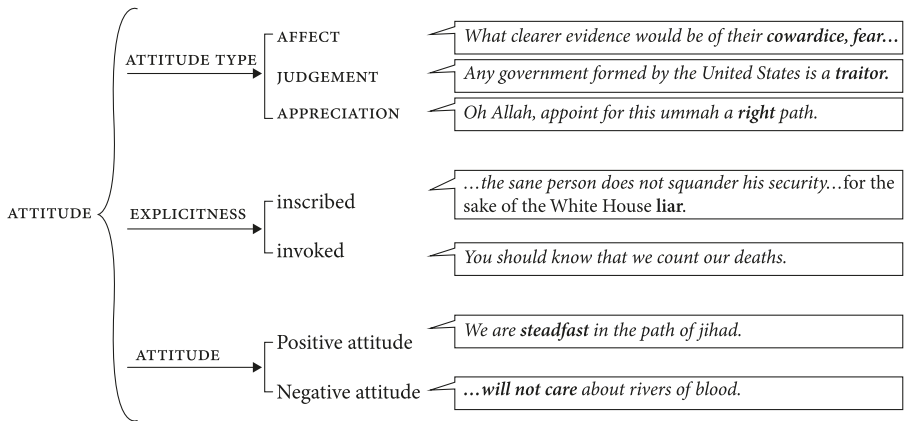


Figure 1. Attitude system used for attitudinal meaning analysis (adapted from Martin and White 2005)

The attitude type system comprises three semantic regions or sub-systems:

- AFFECT: resources and features for expressing emotional reactions and states (e.g., ‘The captain felt fed up’), which may be subcategorized as (UN)HAPPINESS, (IN)SECURITY, (DIS)INCLINATION and (DIS)SATISFACTION.
- JUDGEMENT: resources and features for construing assessments of behaviour with respect to values of social esteem (i.e., NORMALITY, CAPACITY and TENACITY) and values of social sanction (i.e., VERACITY and PROPRIETY) in terms of the rules and regulations set by a society.
- APPRECIATION: resources for estimating the value of things, events, processes and products in terms of aesthetic dimensions (e.g., ‘It was a splendid innings’), and includes REACTION, COMPOSITION and VALUATION parameters.

The following codes of major ATTITUDE types, subtypes, polarity, and explicitness were used for manual labelling of the identified attitudinal features:

- Af (AFFECT): Af/I (AFFECT DIS/INCLINATION), Af/H (AFFECT UN/HAPPINESS), Af/se (AFFECT IN/SECURITY) and Af/sa (AFFECT DIS/SATISFACTION).
- J (JUDGEMENT): J/N (JUDGEMENT NORMALITY), J/C (JUDGEMENT CAPACITY), J/T (JUDGEMENT TENACITY), J/V (JUDGEMENT VERACITY) and J/P (JUDGEMENT PROPRIETY).

- Ap (APPRECIATION): Ap/R (APPRECIATION REACTION), Ap/C (APPRECIATION COMPOSITION) and Ap/V (SOCIAL VALUATION)
- Polarity: + (positive), – (negative).
- Explicitness: S (inscribed), V (invoked).

The Appraisal framework is appropriately situated to identify nuanced functions of attitudinal evaluations within different genres (Millar and Hunston 2015; Schleppegrell 2012), including the terrorist threatening communication genre (e.g., Gales 2010, 2011, 2013). The ‘ATTITUDE’ system permits us to approach the linguistic resources offered in texts as systematic constructions of interpersonal meaning (see Gales 2011, 30–31).

4. Methodology

4.1 Data

Eight written texts of post 9/11 terrorist statements (10,017 words) produced by Osama bin Laden were analyzed in this study. Table 1 shows the title and word-count of each text. The statements address multiple audiences that belong to Muslim communities in Pakistan, Afghanistan, Iraq, America and worldwide. They are al-Qaeda’s “manifestos” of goals and values (see Smith 2004, 419). Al-Qaeda considers America the major “far enemy” and Arab rulers the “near enemy” (Miller 2015). Al-Qaeda’s long-term goals are: “to drive America out of the Muslim world, to destroy Israel, and to create a jihadist caliphate” (Miller 2015, 8). A significant sociopolitical milestone of the dataset and the post 9/11 era is that the US President George W. Bush declared the post 9/11 war in Afghanistan and Iraq as a war of ideas and a war in arms, and he referred to it as a ‘crusade’ – a term which in Muslim world is associated with cultural, physical and economic invasion that aims to subjugate Muslims and desecrate Islam (Ray 2017).

The original Arabic texts of al-Qaeda’s statements were accessed via the publicly available ‘al-Archive al-Jami’, the Collective Archive, issued by al-Buraq al-I’lamiyah media corporation in 2007 (<https://www.cia.gov/library>). English translations of the texts (1–6), drawn from sources such as the Al-Jazeera news network and the CIA Foreign Broadcast Information Service reports, were reviewed for the faithfulness of the translation. This assessment was undertaken by the first author, a native speaker of Arabic and an accredited English-Arabic translator. The accuracy and faithfulness of the translations in conveying socially and culturally shaped lexical and semantic choices was checked and adjusted where needed in order to maintain consistency in the use of terms and their sociocultural reference. For example, the Arabic word *murtad* was not always translated as ‘apostate’,

and the translations occasionally confused apostate (*murtad*) and infidel (*kafir*). These polarizing and evaluatively loaded lexical items are key Islamic terms and concepts and part of the symbolic capital with which the author construes identities and legitimizes violence (Brookes and McEnery 2020); hence, accuracy was essential to our research aims. Confusing who is termed an infidel and who is an apostate would likely result in presenting the author of the texts as an outsider who lacks essential knowledge, which would be unfaithful to the source texts. Missing sections from the translations, as determined through comparison with the original texts, were also translated by the researchers. Texts 7–8 were translated in their entirety by the Arabic-speaking author since no translations were available via the other sources.

Table 1. Overview of al-Qaeda statements

Ser	Title	Word count
1	A message to the American People	2163
2	A message to Iraqis in particular, and Muslims in General	1569
3	A message to the American People (on Aggression on Iraq)	1154
4	A message to the Muslim Ummah	802
5	A message to the People of Iraq in Particular, and Muslims in General	2187
6	A statement on Prince Abdullah bin Abdulaziz’s Initiative for Peace with Israel	1705
7	A message to the Pakistani people	437
8	A message to the Afghani people	546

4.2 Procedure of analysis

The texts were analyzed by focusing on language choices and patterns of attitudinal meaning in order to examine attitudinal evaluation and its relationship to identity. AntConc, a corpus analysis tool (Anthony 2019), was used to generate a word frequency list and to identify concordance lines so as to explore evaluative meanings in more qualitative detail. A list of repeatedly used attitudinally loaded lexical items (lemmas) was generated and specific meanings explored in their context. Following Eggins and Slade (1997, 138), we then examined how these words colour the attitude in texts by:

- classifying attitudinal items into: AFFECT, JUDGEMENT and APPRECIATION, their corresponding subcategories, explicitness (inscribed vs. invoked), and polarity (positive vs. negative);
- summarizing Appraisal choices in terms of total attitudinal items, total items of AFFECT, JUDGEMENT, APPRECIATION and their subcategories;
- interpreting the Appraisal items.

Our use of the word ‘colouring’ is to highlight the way that interpersonal meanings tend to be prosodic or “strung throughout the clause as a continuous motif or colouring” and as such “distributed like a prosody throughout the continuous stretch of discourse” (Halliday 1979, 66).

The resulting repeatedly used attitudinally-loaded lemmas were taken as characteristic of the textually encoded attitude, their semantic features (i.e., functions) and as evidence on how linguistics can “get at the performative nature of identity by studying **repeated discursive patterns** which is what corpus linguistics is about” (Bednarek 2010, 251, emphasis in original). Noteworthy, the semantic prosody of lexical items here refers to some kind of attitudinal meaning associated with these items; it is realized and “expressed through [lexically] formally diverse patterns in a concordance that nevertheless show some positive, negative or otherwise evaluative meaning associated with the node” (Mahlberg 2014, 383).

Following Bednarek (2009), our appraisal analysis examines: repeated attitudinal lexis – given that encoded attitude is often realized lexically (Eggins and Slade 1997, 124) – patterns of ATTITUDE types (and polarity), and their attitudinal targets (AT, henceforth) (i.e. who/what is appraised) (Bednarek 2009). The evaluative lexis conveys the attitudinal values and the AT provides the tool for identifying corresponding social actors (Liu and Hood 2019), contributing to understanding how meaning is construed and words function once used together and what potential connection may exist between configurations of features in dynamic units of linguistic behaviour (Kniffka 2007, 67–68). For example, in

mobilize the Ummah to go to the streets on demonstrations and civil disobedience until the fall of the **traitor regimes**.

‘*Traitor*’ is the attitudinal lexis. Its function is negative JUDGEMENT; it negatively judges the act of the AT (Arab and Muslim states’ ‘*regimes*’), as the following context of incitement informs us:

Therefore, the means are accessible and available to everyone from this Ummah, and they are as follows:

Rejecting the submissive initiative, and incitement to mobilize the Ummah to go to the streets on demonstrations and civil disobedience until the fall of the traitor regimes. [...]

The repeated attitudinal lexical items, their types/functions of ATTITUDE alongside their attitudinal targets are, then, identified and tabulated (see Gales 2011, 35). Findings of tendency of attributing values to the author’s group or opponent’s group as realized co-instantiation of ATTITUDE type with the ATs, i.e. the coupling orientation across texts, characterize interpersonal relationships, including status,

solidarity and power relations, and how the author tends – in Olsson's (2004, 158) terms – to “victimize others” and seeks to be viewed as victimized self whereby justifying terrorist group's violence and existence.

The resulting findings are discussed in relation to the terrorist group's ideology, particularly with reference to two broad variables, which we term: *actional attitude* (where the author attributes values to social actors/groups' specified actions whether dis/approved of) and *relational attitude* (where values are attributed to self and related concepts, other than actions). In so doing, we draw on the general conceptualization of ideology as versions of the world related to “relational models” of viewing the world, i.e., classifications of kinds of social agents, objects, etc., and “actional models”, i.e., “specifications of actions and behaviours required of, permitted or forbidden to, kinds of social agent” (Hodge and Kress 1988, 3). In discussing value attribution, the attitude is also discussed in relation to the underpinning larger sociocultural values pertinent to terrorist aggression: specifically to ‘aggression’ and ‘morality’ (see Smith 2004), given that we are focusing more on judgmental attitude which is the salient type found in the dataset. To serve this discussion, the attitudinal lexical items will be arranged into groups based on their synonymy, and categorized under broad concepts that each group seems to carry (e.g., actions or selves as ‘il/legal’, ‘im/moral’, ‘non/violent’, ‘un/successful’, ‘aggressive’) – this helps account for sociocultural values related to patterns of how the author appraises participants, propriety of their behaviours, whether they live up to socially desirable (to author) values and moral regulations, and how they ought (not) to be (see Thetela 2001, 355).

A close analysis of “who is valuing what” will uncover personal and relational identities. Therefore, the tendency of attributing values to the in-group versus the out-group as realized co-instantiation of ATTITUDE type with the primary participants' ATs are taken and discussed as:

- features of an author's relational identity (i.e., distant from/or superior to ‘Others’ vs. close to in-group's members), including interpersonal status, solidarity and power relations; and
- features of an author's personal (i.e., aggressive and antagonistic towards ‘Others’ vs. caring towards in-group's members) identity.

To account for the reasoning of the author's personal and relational identities, two of the “meta-values” that “cultural moral orders” set expectations for often include: ‘loyalty’ to ‘in-group’, and ‘care’ for ‘harm’ exercised on in-group's members (Van Langenhove 2017, 5) – for more details on meta values, see Haidt and Kesebir (2010). Given that the nature of texts makes it difficult to dissociate the construed personal and relational identities from a group's or audience's master identities, we also draw on the concept of membership categorization (see,

e.g., Sacks 1992; Tann 2010) to explain the author's aggression in relation to broader ideational categories of attitudinal lexical items and interpersonally construed identities: out-group oriented vs. in-group-oriented categories. Broader categories of ideations are taken as means to "facilitate positioning by acting as loci of moral valuations" (Tann 2010, 175). Ideations related to particular social groups/actors will allow for establishing a "category-bound features" (Antaki and Widdicombe 1998, 3–4). That said, however, our main focus is on ideological positioning as being managed through the types of attitudes, chiefly the positive and negative judgement of (categorized groups of) 'Our' versus 'Their' participants and actions. 'Our'-'Their' opposition is taken as being enabled – in Tann's (2010) terms – by ascribing evaluative categories to 'Us' versus 'Them' in an attempt to invite in-group members to position themselves on the author's side and where readers are meant to identify with in-group's ATs and phenomena in a polarizing scene of categories.

5. Findings and discussion

5.1 Encoded attitude in the dataset

Findings of the analysis show that there were 339 occurrences of attitudinally loaded lexical items (totalling 45 repeatedly used lexemes). While we note that the list of lexemes accounted for is by no means exhaustive, our focus is on patterns of attitudinal meanings of the repeated occurrences and on showcasing how form-based attitudinal functions can help investigators examine personal and relational identities within a set of texts. The most frequent word was 'fight' which appeared in all the texts, followed by 'kill', found repeatedly in 7/8 texts. The most frequent words were in semantic domains such as violence, conflict and the military (e.g., *fight*, *kill*, *jihad*, *bombing*, *crusade*, *support*, *enemy*, *defence*, and *destroy*). The words were grouped according to the match in number of occurrences (see Figure 2), producing groups of words of similar word frequency. For example, *destr** (destroy, destroyed, destroying, and destruction) and *hypocri** (hypocrisy and hypocrite) carried the same frequency and thus grouped together. Synonyms such as *traitor* or *treachery* and *treason(ous)* were sorted as one lemma and counted together.

A summary of encoded attitudinal features in terms of (sub)categories, polarity and explicitness is displayed below (see Table 2), followed by a descriptive summary of attitude types total choices and their interpretation. The lexemes were evaluated for their attitudinal load by exploring each lexeme in contexts (i.e., concordance lines). The words in the 'Attitudinal lexis' column were sorted

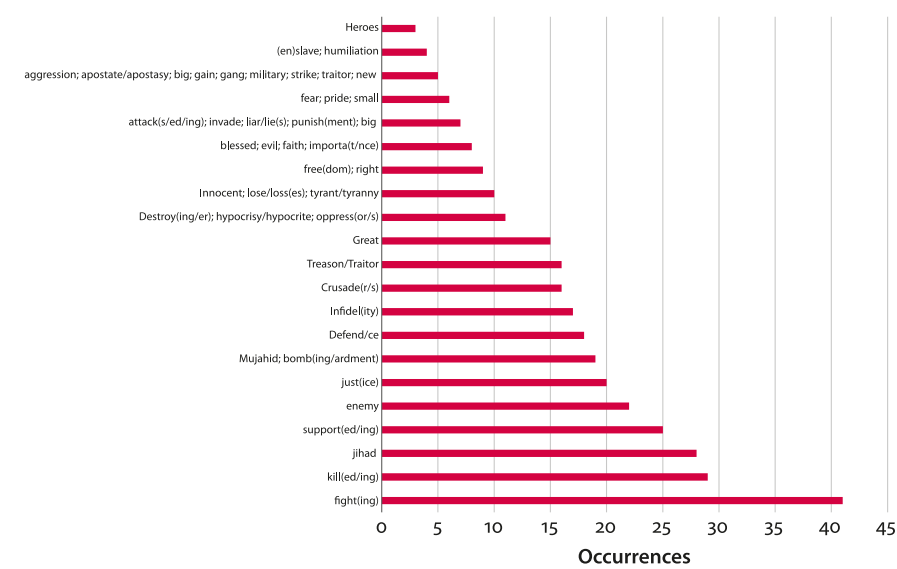


Figure 2. Repeated, attitudinally-loaded lexical items

and tabulated manually. The (sub)category of each lexeme, its polarity type and explicitness were examined in context and were altogether tabulated in a coding sheet and exemplified (see Table 3).

Table 2. Summary of repeatedly used attitudinal lexical items

Category (Af/J/Ap)	Subcategory	Polarity (+/-)	Explicitness (S/V)	Total
Affect	H	-	S	1
	S	-	S	1
Appreciation	V	+	S	4
	V	-	S	2
Judgement	P	-	S	29
	P	+	V	2
	P	+	S	1
	N	+	S	2
	T	+	S	1
	T	-	S	2

The analysis shows an author who is very interpersonally involved in the communication. The general tendency of repeated instances of attitudinal lexis is of negative polarity and inscribed JUDGEMENT (37 repeatedly used lexical items) (see Table 2). Only two lexical items are of the AFFECT type (*fear*, which is of ‘INSE-

CURITY' subcategory, chiefly couples with the American troops (Example 1); and *pride*, of the 'HAPPINESS' subcategory coupling with *mujahidin* and *sons of Muslim Ummah* (Example 2). Six items are of the 'APPRECIATION' type: four positive items evaluating the author's group and associated ATs, and two items of negative polarity evaluating opponents' phenomena, i.e., *crusade*, and opponents' view of Muslim ummah's wealth and Iraqi oil (see Examples (3)–(4)). As such, the author uses attitudinal expressions recurrently, favouring JUDGEMENT (SOCIAL SANCTION:IM/PROPRIETY) in assessing people in terms of their conformity to the author's desirable behaviour (religious and moral) standards. 82% of the lexical items are of JUDGEMENT type, warranting further investigation as salient encoded attitude (see Section 5.2). Table 3 below provides more examples of repeatedly used attitudinal lexical items

- (1) *Third, it has become clear to us [...] that, in combat, the enemy mainly depends on psychological warfare, given their huge propaganda machine, likewise, on the intense air strikes so as to conceal their most prominent weakness points, which are fear, cowardice, and the absence of fighting spirit among the American soldiers.*
- (2) *Their [tyrants and traitors] fate is a proof of the faith and pride upheld by the sons of this Ummah.*
- (3) *Observe Allah for what you have been entrusted for and the great faith and hope people have in you.* (+ Ap)
- (4) *We ask Allah to grant him [Mullah Mohammad Omar] victory over the forces of infidelity and tyranny, and to destroy the new Jewish Crusade on the soil of Pakistan and Afghanistan.* (– Ap)

Table 3. Coding sheet for the encoded attitude – repeatedly used attitudinal lexical items

Attitudinal lexis	Category (Af/J/Ap)	Subcategory	Polarity (+/–)	Explicitness (S/V)
Jihad	J	P	+	V
Enemy	J	P	–	S
Injust(ice)/ unjust	J	P	–	S
Bomb(ing) (a US act)	J	P	–	S
Great	Ap	V	+	S
Hypocrisy/hypocrite	J	P	–	S
Oppress(or/s)	J	P	–	S
Innocent	J	N	+	S
Blessed	Ap	V	+	S
Fear	Af	S	–	S

The repeated JUDGEMENT in the dataset accords with four social value-categories proposed by Smith (2004) as being characteristic of a terrorist group's rhetoric. These categories are the following:

- Dominance and aggression: values which colour texts with aggression and confrontation. These include examples valuing fighting, punishing, retaliating, and victory. They are clearly realized in *kill, tyrant/tyranny, oppressor, humiliation, jihad, mujahid, bombing/ bombardment, crusade, support, enemy, defence, strike, aggression, invade, punish, military, attack* and *destroy*.
- Morality and truthfulness: valuing being good in a moral sense (doing the right or wrong) and valuing truth-speaking and acting. Instances of these values include *steadfast, hero, liar, gang, (en)slave, treason/traitor, faithful, free, evil*, and *hypocrite*.
- Justice and tolerance: valuing equality, fairness, people's rights, diversity and absence of hostility. These values are realized in words like *free, enslave, tyranny, innocent*, and *injust(ice)*.
- Culture and religion: valuing religious beliefs and practices, and group's traditions. Instances include *jihad, mujahid, apostacy, apostate, hypocrisy*, and *infidel(ity)*.

The categorization indicates a selection of attitudinal lexical items, based on distinct parameters of value. The repeated JUDGEMENT offers support to earlier research findings (e.g., Smith 2004) that lexical choices in terrorist groups' statements are more likely to be centered around socio-cultural values of aggression, morality, justice, and culture and religion. The current findings show that construed attitudinal meanings are also centered on these socio-cultural value parameters. A close examination of these findings reveals, however, that some values in the 'culture and religion' category (e.g., *jihad* and *mujahid*, praised in Islam once justified and legitimate, and *hypocrisy* condemned in Islamic texts) and 'justice and tolerance' category (e.g., *tyranny* and *enslave*) can be simultaneously labeled as 'dominance and aggression', and 'morality and truthfulness' categories, respectively. This overlap contributes to presenting 'dominance and aggression' and 'morality and truthfulness' categories as the two salient features of the semantic domains and values of the repeated, attitudinal lexis in the dataset. In addition, words such as *jihad* can be argued to be related to 'morality' (as part of the Islamic moral order to restore what is a 'right') and 'justice' categories. As such, this overlap requires more nuanced analysis of the contexts of words and how they relate to the author's value system which maps out to a broader cultural (namely, religious) moral order that, according to Van Langenhove (2017) includes moral evaluations and opinions that go back to religious codes and many habits and prescriptions that people may take for granted. In other words, what do the repeated

JUDGEMENT labels of an in-group’s and an out group’s behaviours reveal about an interpersonal/inter-group conflict? And what cultural or ideological reasoning do these judgements have?

An important argument and investigation, as such, is to identify who is represented as valuing which social values: a rhetorical technique that is strategically used by the author to positively or negatively appraise social actors – which is the focus of the next section. The representation of self and others justifies: the author’s relational (distant) and personal (aggressive and hostile) identities, and the purpose of the terrorist group’s existence and acts, including aggression and mobilizing new followers (Smith 2004); and it is likely to “mark off socially and ideologically distinct areas of experience” of the author (Fowler 1991, 84). The reasoning of the author’s aggression will be explained in relation to the activated cultural moral order-meta-values.

5.2 Judgement of participants and characteristic personal and relational identity

Given that the analyzed texts contain predominantly judgmental attitude, we view them as being normative JUDGEMENT-based terrorist threatening texts. In these texts, the author draws a SOCIAL SANCTION value-related distinction between participants based on whether the actions performed by the participants are (un)acceptable or (un)necessary according to the author’s underpinning socio-cultural value system. Table 4 shows a shorter version of repeated expressions of JUDGEMENT, corresponding JUDGEMENT subcategories, and the social actors’ ATs as found in the concordance lines (and more extended in Appendix 1). The words in ‘Attitudinal lexis’ column were tabulated from most frequent to least frequent.

Table 4. Frequent expressions of JUDGEMENT underlying personal and relational identity

Attitudinal lexis	Judgement	Attitudinal target
Fight	– P (pos) ^{*a}	– act performed by the author’s group
	– p	– act performed by the US troops
Kill	– P (pos) [*]	– act performed by the author’s group
	– P	– act performed by the US and US allies
Jihad	+ P	– act performed by the author’s group
Support	+ P	– act by whoever to the side of (i.e. with) America; act by whoever to the side of ‘infidel’ parties; act by the US towards Israel
		– act by the author’s group

Table 4. (continued)

Attitudinal		
lexis	Judgement	Attitudinal target
Defend/defence	+ P	– acts performed by the author’s group – acts performed by the Americans
Infidel(ity)	– P	– heads of Islamic states; parties such as the Arab Socialist Ba’th and Socialists in Baghdad or Aden; non-Muslim camp fighting against Muslims; everyone who cooperates with the United States or its offshoots – act of war waged by America and its allies; forces of the new Jewish Crusade
Crusade(r)	– P	– US forces and their allies – the act/war by the US – Bush the senior; Bush the junior
Traitor*	– P	– act of Prince Abdullah bin Abdelaziz (of Saudi Arabia) – Iraq and Arab governments – the toppled and new president of Iraq – all Arab governments – any government in the region formed by the United States – Arab rulers
Destroy	– P (pos)* – P	– act performed by al-Qaeda – act performed by Israel supported by the US – act performed by the US
Hypocrisy/hypocrite	– P	– US led-forces – rulers of Arab countries
Oppress(or)	– P	– Americans – Arab rulers
Innocent	+ N	– women and children affected

a. * *fight, kill, destroy and attack* are lexical items that provide typical instances of attitudinal inscription, i.e. in White’s (2006) terms, they carry a negative attitudinal value which is largely fixed and stable across a wide range of contexts. They are typical ‘violent’ words that are used to suspect violence and communicated threats (see, e.g., Gales 2010; Muschalik 2018). Even though these lemmas encode acts and concepts that are valued, justified and positive in the eyes of the author, the author still represents the acts through a repetition of largely negative lexical items he describes his opponents with (see Gales 2011, 35–36). This is why they are labelled negatively. However, they are labelled as positive (in brackets) to refer to them as positive calls and acts for the author in his texts – a coding practice followed by Gales (2011).

Table 4 shows the repeatedly used attitudinal lexical items. It displays more use of the IMPROPRIETY function than any other JUDGEMENT functions. There is a limited use of the positive JUDGEMENT instances of TENACITY and NORMALITY targeting in-group’s adherence to socially desirable standards. These instances

are attached to the terrorist group's ATs (namely, *mujahidin*) and its wider audience's ATs (e.g., *victim women and children*). 84% of the lexical items of JUDGEMENT type are of negative polarity where the author represents and evaluates social actors and their behaviours in terms of unethicity, i.e., in terms of what defies the author's view – in Iedema et al.'s (1994, 201) terms – of “a system of social necessity” as exemplified later in this section. The increased repetition of inscribed judgmental lexical items infused with negative polarity of IMPROPRIETY type paints a prosodic picture of texts with a high degree of perceived improper behaviours and violent intention underlying the communication. The dominating degree of negative attitudes are due to the high rate of repeated IMPROPRIETY-laden (specifically, ‘aggression’ and ‘immorality’ value-based) words used in “othering” and constructing selves as threats to one another (see, e.g., Baker and Vessey 2018).

Investigation of the context of lexical items in Table 4 above reveals information about how a dichotomous distinction of ‘Us’ (the author's group and audience) vs. ‘Them’ (the opponents and victims) is being drawn – see Gales' (2011, 33–34) similar finding concerning texts of the terrorist group Army of God. The texts position the author favourably and the opponents negatively. This positive/negative positioning is achieved by endowing semantic roles to social actors (see, e.g., Sykes 1988; van Leeuwen 1996; White 2006), and basing evaluative language on the author's value system, the two main features on which we focus our discussion. The dominating inscribed negative JUDGEMENT of ATs sets the threatening tone of the texts as an explicit, ethics-based confrontation that ultimately seeks to affirm dis-alignment and highlight contested values with opponents. The dominant prosodic patterning of JUDGEMENT features and the attitude-AT coupling disposition is indicative of the author's feelings of victimization and hostile intentions to victimize others. For example, in Example (5), *they* (underlined) is the AT and the agent of the negative process/behaviour *fight* (in bold). The acted upon is *Islam* and, thus, Muslims. The AT is negatively judged for IMPROPRIETY. In Example (6) (Arab) *regimes* (underlined) is the AT that is appraised negatively with IMPROPRIETY as *traitor* (in bold) to their societies, which justifies the author's inciting the addressed audience to protest and enact civil disobedience.

- (5) *They [Bush and his supporters] came out to **fight** Islam under the falsifying name of 'fighting terrorism'.*
- (6) *mobilize the Ummah to go to the streets on demonstrations and civil disobedience until the fall of the **traitor** regimes.*

This patterning also serves the goal of presenting the menacing ‘other’ – in Ochs and Taylor's (1995 cited in Bucholtz and Hall 2005, 596) terms – as problematizer while ‘Us’ as problematizee. This representation serves othering the problema-

tizer and provides a moral reasoning for a violent response underpinned by the meta-value of 'care' for 'harm' imposed on 'us', presenting the author as close and protagonist to the problematized in-group. Texts also, while representing the author as a fighter and with negatively loaded attitudinal expressions, construe opponents (chiefly the United States) as powerful and construe the author (and al-Qaeda) as equally powerful. Consider Examples (7)–(9).

- (7) *Third, it has become clear to us from our defence and **fight** against the American enemy...*
- (8) *We incite our brothers to **fight** you [the Americans].*
- (9) *I say to the American people: Allah willing, we are continuing **fighting** you. We will continue the **martyrdom** operations inside and outside the United States until you terminate your injustice [...].*

But, how is the author representing his group favourably (or positively) when coupling his group with, for example, the act of *fighting*? The act of fighting is carried out by the author and opponents and, thus, they are both endowed with the IMPROPRIETY value and represented as valuing aggression; however, the author draws a line between 'our' *fight* and 'their' *fight* based on a cultural group-specific value system; through this lens 'they' are considered 'legitimate enemy'. This discursively construed enmity is founded on the contrast between the perceived negative aspects of the opponents' personal and master identities, and the claimed positive aspects of the author's personal and master identities (Cotler and Grossman 2009; Musolff 2015). In this sense, attitudinal stances are argued to be acts of identity. Examining the concordance lines revealed that 'we' fight

- *the American enemy;*
- *the crusaders;*
- *the disbelievers and hypocrites;*
- *the Romans;*
- *for the cause of Allah;*
- *against the allies of Satan;*
- *for Allah's word to become superior;*
- *responding to Allah's word;*
- *until injustices are faded away.*

Consider 10–11:

- (10) *It will not be harmful in such circumstances if the interests of Muslims intersect with the interests of the Socialists in the **fight** against the Crusaders, despite our belief and declaration of the infidelity of the Socialists.*

- (11) *In conclusion, I say to the American people: Allah willing, we are continuing fight you.*

The author, as such, presents himself as antagonist to those on the side of 'crusaders' and distant from the out-groups; thus his aggression is presented as acceptable to in-group members. 'Our' fight is represented as being against the demonized and dehumanized 'other' (*allies of Satan*) and thus their personal identity, and those who are out of 'our' circle of religious belief (e.g., *crusaders*, and *disbelievers*) and ethnonationalist identity (*the Romans*, and *the Americans*). Apparently, relational attitude seems to go hand in hand with categorizing who people are and what aspects of personal and master identities they possess. This categorization-based relationship ultimately establishes a justified and permitted actional attitude. Conversely, 'they' (the opponents) are represented as *lack[ing] a fair cause to defend*, and they fight:

- *us; the Faith; Islam; the Ummah of beloved Mohammad;*
- *under the falsifying name of fighting terrorism;*
- *they fight for capitalists, usury takers, and the merchants, etc.*

Consider the following examples:

- (12) *And the Romans have gathered under the banner of the cross to fight the Ummah of beloved Mohammad, may Allah's peace and blessings be upon him.*
- (13) *They only fight for capitalists, usury takers, and the merchants of arms and oil, including the criminal gang at the White House.*

The same line between 'we' and 'they' is found in the use of the word 'attack' which couples IMPROPRIETY with the act performed by the Americans against Muslim sanctities, al-Qaeda, Muslims in Iraq, and 'our' Ummah. The word 'attack' is also used to evaluate the author's act, but contextualized as in response to what the Americans are doing in Afghanistan, Pakistan, Iraq, etc. Accordingly, the author presents 'our' fight as ethical and desirable, while 'their' fight is condemned and unethical. The reasoning, hence, for the author's and 'our' attacks is contextualized as emerging from the meta value of 'our' loyalty to a wider sociocultural in-group perceptions, presenting the author as being close to and caring for the in-group members.

The same features of appraisal are used in relation to 'our' and 'their' performed act of 'killing'. On the one hand, 'we' kill(ed), for example,

- *a dozen Americans in Nairobi and Dar es Salaam;*
- *the Americans;*
- *the polytheist.*

Consider the following:

- (14) *Therefore, the means are accessible and available to everyone from this Ummah, and they are as follows: [...] **Killing** the Americans with bullets, knives, stones, etc.*

On the other hand, ‘they’ kill, for example,

- *our sons; Muslims in Iraq; innocent women and children; our women and children; a million innocent children (in Iraq); men (in Palestine); Lebanese;*
- *for ‘their’ own greed and the ambitions in Iraq and its oil; and fulfilling the demand of the Zionist lobby.*

See, for example:

- (15) *[I]t triggered in my mind that we should punish the oppressor in kind, and should destroy towers in America so that they taste some of what we tasted, and they refrain from **killing** our women and children.*
- (16) *You should know that we count our deaths, may Allah have mercy on them, particularly those **killed** in Palestine at the hands of your allies, the Jews.*

The dichotomous representation of actions, for example, ‘we-they’ kill and whom the victim is, emphasizes – in du Bois’s (2007, 140) terms – the dialogism and thus subjectivity in texts. The speaker reports what ‘others’ did and ‘their’ attitude towards ‘us’. By using attitudinal expressions such as *fight* and *kill*, the author does not merely judge ‘our’ and ‘their’ behaviour. He is constructing a (US) threat and generating fear – see (5) and (7) above – a threat which the ‘other’ is the source of, and fear from that source of threat to ‘our’ ideological and physical interests, and thus presenting social actors as distant, “legitimizing” ‘our’ aggression and “coercing” in-group audiences to support proposed action (Cap 2017, 9). This attitude is contradictory to many ‘our’ vs. ‘their’ situations in which the defined opposing groups are separated by a positive vs. negative asymmetry (see, e.g., Reynolds, Turner and Haslam 2000). Both ‘we’ and ‘they’ are represented as performing acts of the IMPROPRIETY type (as in the communicated threat in Example (9)), but the context informs the ideal in-group reader whom ‘we’ are fighting or killing and why (i.e. in defence). In other words, ‘our’ act of killing is based on the reasoning of loyalty to in-group and care for harm against in-group, and thus for the good of ‘our’ ‘borderless’ nation (ummah) and its members’ master identity aspects. This reasoning also underpins the author’s distant and aggressive identity. In other words, a justified and ethical in-group’s ‘fight’ is presented as a positive act that is carried out within the framework of inter-group ethical struggle.

The prosodic patterning of negatively evaluating others’ action-representation is also found in coupling *bombing* (which carries negative evalu-

ation) with opponents as the only Agent performing the act of bombing, while ‘us’ and ‘our’ women, children, etc. are represented as the Affected (i.e., targets of violence) (Example 17). This representation constructs threat and conceptualizes it as being physical, i.e., targeting lives, and non-physical, i.e., imposing danger on ‘our’ collective interests, values and so forth (Cap 2017, 9). Similarly, the word *invade* was used to describe the opponents’ acts as aggression against ‘us’ (Example 18). In addition, *destroy* negatively describes ‘our’ and ‘their’ acts, but ‘they’ includes the USA and Israel that destroyed buildings in Lebanon, Iraq and elsewhere whereas ‘we’ destroyed the US buildings in response (Example 19). ‘Strike’ was used exclusively to describe the author’s group’s swift and powerful acts. As such, we argue that opponents are attributed (and viewed as valuing) antagonistic values and adversarial ideologies encroaching on ‘our’ ideological and physical territories – a strategy found also in political discourse (see Cap 2017, 16–17). This technique of threat construction and conceptualization is used in the texts as part of the author’s/al-Qaeda’s need for a degree of ideological justification to maintain his violent identity and al-Qaeda’s existence and coercive capacity (see Malešević 2019, 188–189). This technique provides a moral reasoning for the author’s and ‘our’ aggression, that is based on the meta-value of ‘harm’ and concerns for ‘our’ suffering’.

- (17) *But when a dozen people of them were killed in Nairobi and Dar es Salaam, Afghanistan and Iraq were **bombarded**.*
- (18) *They have underestimated you, fooled you, **invaded** Iraq once again, and lied to you and the entire world.*
- (19) *If so, then let him [Bush] explain to us why we did not **strike**, for example, Sweden?*

The texts serve the “coercive” function of seeking to affect their audience’s stances (Sachs 2013, 2). This rhetorical effect, which we term the ‘moral coerciveness’ function, results from the strategic stimulation of fear from and hostility towards opponents. The constructed threat influences audience’s choices and stances through fear and anger, brings sympathy and support to the violent cause (McCauley and Mosalenko 2016) and underpins the moral justification – i.e., to believe it is permissible to inflict harm on opponents. Perceptions of ATs as such manufacture fear and social anxiety, features that ultimately serve to justify the author’s aggression (see Cap 2017, xi), and in response receive the audience’s approval of contextualized relational and actional attitudes.

Furthermore, the positive value of *defend/defence* is largely used to appraise ‘our’ acts, underpinned by ‘harm/care’ meta-value and thus reasoning of concerns for in-group’s members suffering. The act of defence by the author/al-Qaeda con-

structs him as close, protagonist and caring towards in-groups. When used in relation to ‘their’ acts, the cause and moral motive is questioned by the author, making ‘our’ acts of defence ethically grounded, acceptable and reasonable, contrary to ‘their’ acts. While there is a causal link between ‘defend’/‘defence’ for both ‘our’ and ‘their’ ATs, ‘their defence’ or ‘fight for’ is framed negatively through the distinction made between broad categories of ideations. In other words, ‘their’ ATs “facilitate positioning by acting as loci of moral valuations that may translate to moral expectations, and these expectations in turn afford [negative] interpretations of social actions associated with [‘their’] categories, inducing further evaluations” (Tann 2010, 175). The general categorization of ‘their’ ideations allows for establishing ‘their’ “category-bound [negative] features” (Antaki and Widdicombe 1998, 3–4). Departing from this understanding, the Americans were represented as *lacking a fair cause to defend* and fight for; conversely, ‘we’ defend *vulnerable sons, brothers, and sisters in Palestine and in many Islamic countries*, and ‘our’ sanctities. This justification is emphasized in the rhetorical questions in Example (20) where the author expects the answer ‘no’ (see White 2003), thus confirming previous assertions (Heritage 2012):

- (20) *Should a man be blamed for **defending** his sanctuary? Is **self-defence** and punishing the aggressor in kind vilified terrorism?*

The moral coerciveness is further enhanced by presenting ‘self’ as defenders of culture-specific values by using ‘permitted’ values, namely *jihad* as a means of resisting evil (Wignell et al. 2017). By drawing on the actional model of his ideology, the author proposes *jihad* as a desirable (re)actional attitude, to which *everyone is required to join and strive for*. *Jihad* is presented as a form of action based on the meta-value of ‘loyalty’ to in-group and concerns related to obligations towards the in-group (e.g., self-sacrifice for the benefit of the in-group). *Jihad* is a term with a general meaning of a meritorious struggle made to promote what is right and to prevent what is wrong (Afsaruddin 2020). Basically, the Quran permits *jihad* as a violent act in self-defence, only against actual aggressors, and when declared by the legitimate ruler (Caliph) (Afsaruddin 2020). According to the Islamic Supreme Council of America (2016 cited in Wignell et al. 2017), the use of force as part of *jihad* is allowed, only if there is no peaceful alternative for self-defence. However, similar to the acts of violence motivated by political and secular concerns (termed sometimes as ‘*jihad*’ and thus granted religious ‘legitimacy’), proscribed terrorist groups such as al-Qaeda tend to label their acts as ‘*jihad*’ despite their politically motivated terrorist acts (Malešević 2019). The author portrays *jihad*, an aggression-related value, positively by describing *jihad* as, for example,

- commendable; blessed;
- by which *pride and dignity are attained*;
- it must continue until the rise of an Islamic government which rules by Allah's religion.

As such, the negative load of 'jihad' as a value of aggression appears to be backgrounded to the significance of the cause of jihad as part of "perceived religious obligations and/or divine messages [that] transcend social consciousness and social obligations" (Schbley 2006, 292) whose sources (of authority) need be obeyed (Baker and Vessey 2018, 274). Consider the following example,

- (21) *So, expect the reward for Jihad from Allah.*
- (22) *Hence, Jihad must continue until the rise of an Islamic government which rules by Allah's religion.*

The representation of jihad as a value thus offers a "juxtaposition to the positive/negative alignment of social actors" (Gales 2011, 36). This positive alignment is obvious in the (a) positively infused use of the item *mujahid* (i.e. fighters) in, e.g.,

- *mujahidin brothers in Iraq; courageous mujahidin; faithful mujahidin; our mujahid Emir; the mujahid brother doctor Ayman al-Zawahiri;*

and (b) in foregrounding religious symbolism such as upholding the Quran along with carrying the sword as a religious obligation as in evaluating the Afghani people as being:

- *steadfast, defiant, mujahid people who carried the sword with one hand and the Noble Qur'an with the other.*

As such, the values of 'jihad' and 'destruction' when caused by 'us' are represented as acceptable and necessary. These values of aggression are also reiterated in the use of the word *punish* which describes 'our' act against those who 'deserve' it for their lack of PROPRIETY (e.g., for being *oppressors* and *aggressors*), as in *punish the oppressor; punish the aggressor*, and *the punishment they deserve*. Consider the following example where the author constructs his aggressive identity, yet underpinned by the moral reasoning of care for harm that was imposed on the Lebanese:

- (23) *While I was looking at those demolished towers in Lebanon, it triggered in my mind that we should **punish** the oppressor in kind*

An interesting case of attitudinal stance is found in the analysis of the attitudinal expression *support*. The analysis showed that despite the typically positive meaning associated with the word, the polarity of its attitudinal value tended to change

according to the social actor who is being supported, i.e. in the “beneficialised” role (van Leeuwen 1996, 43). Opponents *support* one another.

- *to kill Muslims*; they support the *butcher against the victim* and *the aggressor against the innocent child*.

But ‘we’ *support* the oppressed, *the Mujahidin*, etc. As such, the author’s aggression is presented as a form of care for the in-group, and it is, therefore, justified. ‘We’ act violently against those who value injustice and are *unjust*; ‘we’ act in response to the transgression of a moral standard by ‘other’ participants (e.g., regimes in the Muslim world, and US-led coalition). For instance, the author mentions that events of 9/11

- *came in response to those great injustices*; and states that
- *we will continue the martyrdom operations inside and outside the United States until you terminate your injustice*,

presenting the author as valuing justice, and the opponents as valuing injustice.

The analysis revealed a pattern of depicting rulers of Muslim countries as illegitimate with the negative evaluation realized by words such as *infidel*, *traitor*, *hypocrite* and *tyrant* – see the examples below. These attitudinal expressions function as a means of – in Gordon’s (2018) and Leets and Giles’ (1997) terms – delegitimization and defamation, whereby social actors’ personal aspects that are associated with (and determined by) their interactional roles or identities as rulers are attacked. These expressions of negative PROPRIETY are “face attacks” on Arab rulers that implicate “an absence of a desirable identity [and] the presence of a disvalued one” (Tracy 2008, 176). Yet, they are likely to receive audience approval given that the messages generally tend to echo major concerns of Muslim-majority countries, including the illegitimacy of rulers who support America and Arab audiences’ desire to rebel against rulers’ tyranny, discrimination, inequality, etc. (see Miller 2015, 10). Tracking the ATs in our set of texts, Arab rulers were represented as aligned with America, and thus both parties were evaluated with similar negative attitudinal expressions: *hypocrite*, *infidel*, *oppressor*, *tyrant*, *unjust*, *enslaving*, *lying* and *apostate* – see Examples (24)–(26) below.

- (24) *Beware of supporting the Crusader US forces and their allies. Everyone who cooperates with the United States or its off-shoots, regardless of names and titles, is infidel...*
- (25) *Amid this unjust war, the war of infidels and debauchees waged by America along with its allies and traitor-agents, we would like to emphasise on a number of important points...*
- (26) *O Allah, it is for thee to deal with the tyrants of Arabs and non-Arabs.*

This use of similar negative attitudinal expressions to describe American and Arab rulers excludes the Arab rulers and their regimes as well as represents them as distant ‘others’. This exclusion of Arab rulers and representation of ‘self’ in opposition to the ‘delegitimized’ rulers, however, entails that the author adopts an ideology that is disapproved of by those rulers, thus setting the stage for interpersonally aggressive behaviour (Schbley 2006). The author’s stances and actional attitude have their reasoning in the meta-value of ‘harm’, i.e., obligations towards concerns for harm imposed on ‘us’ and the actional model of ideology through which a reaction is perceived as permitted and legitimate – see Example (27).

- (27) *Praise is due to Allah who created the creation for his worship, commanded them to be just, and permitted the oppressed to retaliate against the oppressor in kind*

Interestingly, instances of attacking master (particularly religious) aspects of ATs’ identities are frequently found in the corpus. The repeated use of the *infidel(ity)* value demarks a line between the author’s perceived camp of faith and his opponents’ camp of infidelity. The IMPROPRIETY infused item *infidel(ity)* has been found in devaluing acts of a wide range of opponents; these include America and its allies worldwide, heads of Islamic states who are accused of being *split from their religion and having betrayed the Ummah*, and *non-Islamic parties* such as the *Arab Socialist Ba’th party*. The immoral value, *traitor*, attributed to opponents represents the author’s aggression as a moral response to social actors valuing ‘treachery’, as in:

- Prince Abdullah bin Abdelaziz (of Saudi Arabia) for giving *the enemy, the crusader, and the infidel* (the US military) permission to enter the *land of the Two Holy Mosques* and his cooperation in signing the Oslo agreement, and
- *Iraq and Arab governments serving the US interests, all Arab governments*, etc.

This representation serves to portray the author in a higher moral status than his far and near enemies.

The repeated use of these identified sets of attitudinal lexical items, their “form-based functional patterns” (Gales 2010, 264) and underpinning (meta) value parameters in relation to ‘us’ and ‘them’ serve, as also found in Farkas, Schou and Neumayer (2018), to (re)produce and sustain antagonism between social groups of ethnonationalist, cultural and religious identities, having the potential to prompt audiences’ reactions. The author tends to rely on “generally circulated” intertextual meanings, and oft-restated familiar beliefs with ideal audiences (Bazerman 2003, 87). These highlight core values that underpin the author’s/organization’s ideology, and thus represent the organization as operating on behalf of (and defending) the interests of the entire sociocultural community,

i.e. Muslims. This repetition of these value-loaded lexical items emphasizes ideology constituents (or value instances) which are offered as necessary to sustain ummah's "relationships of both power and solidarity", and the desired social order (Hodge and Kress 1988, 3).

6. Conclusion and further research

This paper has demonstrated how attitudinal meaning analysis can help unveil attitudinal stances, and personal and relational identity in terrorist statements. We drew mainly on the Appraisal framework to explore repeated ATTITUDE markers in a set of threatening statements produced by Osama bin Laden in order to identify how patterns of evaluative meanings and ideological positions can illuminate patterns of identity. Just as the markedness of "[h]igh frequency lexicon could discriminate the works of authors from each other" (Olsson 2008, 37), repeated attitudinal *form-based functional patterns* are shown to play a pivotal role as an ideological tool and identity-marker. Results have shown that terrorist threatening communication is clearly linked to judgmental attitudes and certain underpinning sets of value parameters. Attitudinal stances thus appear to work as cues for the characterization of the author (see Culpeper 2001, 190). They were repeatedly used by the author as a way of depicting himself as embodying particular values, ways of feeling and thus personal and relational identity, values and ways of feeling (Culpeper 2001, 192–193). The construed personal and relational identities were found fundamentally relevant to the author's and audiences' master identity (religion) and categories. The invited-for violence was based on cultural (religious) reasoning and associated with two main (ideological) meta values: loyalty to the in-group, and care for harm targeting in-group members. These meta-values were part of the author's relational and actional models of ideology, determining who 'we' and 'they' as well as associated phenomena are, and determining which actions are forbidden, permitted and/or required. In-group's actional attitude, i.e., violence, was presented as required and acceptable, underpinned by the actional model of the author/al-Qaeda.

The discursive patterns of authorial identity and sociocultural value parameters explored revealed the author's antagonism, aggressive inclination, determined and acrimonious tendencies, moral distance and negative solidarity towards opponents. In other words, they uncovered a particular personal and relational identity – associated with other aspects of master identities. Morality was attributed to 'self', presenting the author with a higher level of morality and opponents as evil, with a lower level of morality and, thus, requiring punishment. Attitudinal language, as such, can establish inclusion and exclusion status, and

determine power relations, thus establishing ideologically opposing poles – coalitions and enemies (Leets and Giles 1997; Mateo and Yus 2013). The current study offers strong support for earlier research showing that groups which engage in aggression are more likely to view themselves as morally superior to their opponents (see, e.g., Bandura 1999; Palmer 1995 cited in Smith 2004). The findings also support Smith's (2004, 431) suggestion on potential grounds for suspicion of terrorist violence: when trying to predict whether an author or a group is likely to engage in terrorist acts, it is important to examine how the author describes his group ATs, and how they describe the opponents'.

The discursive patterns of identity found in the analysis showed the role of attitudinal stances in getting at one's aggressive identity (see Bednarek 2010) and at how an author may attack particular aspects of opponents' identities (see Culpeper et al. 2017). The increased repetition of negative JUDGEMENT could scale up the author's judgmental interpersonal relationships and his reflected hostile attitude. The increased frequency also constructed the "aloof, cool verbal style" which is linked to controlling behaviour (Weintraub 2003, 145). The increased use of JUDGEMENT, together with the reduced use of AFFECT, indicates terrorist texts with less affectual mode of violence (see Meloy 2001, 1212) and more antipathy towards the out-group's social actors, distancing the author from emotional or sympathetic connections and strengthening his overall appearance of ideological determination (Gales 2010, 249). The author's set of texts are thus more ideologically and less emotionally oriented. Expressions of JUDGEMENT tended to support an 'us' vs. 'them' dichotomy based on some underpinning sociocultural parameters of values which established two major rival social groups (Thetela 2001). The two main value categories were 'dominance and aggression' and 'morality'. The repeated use of violent judgmental words can be thought of as being indicative of "predatory violence" that is ideologically motivated to gratify desire for power, territorial dominance/control and revenge (Meloy 2001, 1212; Meloy et al. 2004, 1088) based on a particular group's value systems.

The findings also showed that not only terrorist actions but also linguistically realized attitudinal stances could be aggressive – a finding aligned with Janicki's (2017) view of aggression which includes all kinds of phenomena (behaviours, activities, situations, attitudes, etc.). Further, the encoded attitude displayed a role in constructing solidarity between the author and ideal audiences through using more instances of a particular type of attitude (i.e., JUDGEMENT) which presented inter-group relations in ethical codes.

In addition, the analysis indicated that sharing values repeatedly in the area of social sanction underpins a duty and "religious observances", i.e., what should (not) be done in observance of religious regulations, legal and ethical social norms (Baker and Vessey 2018; Martin and White 2005, 52). Moreover, although

the most frequent values are more of the social sanction type codified in the dataset, this frequent use of particular attitude type does not entail not sharing values in the area of social esteem, which is “critical to the formation of social networks” (Martin and White 2005, 52). A future study of larger corpus of al-Qaeda and other terrorist organizations’ corpora may yield corroborating insights into the extent different organizations encode different types of attitude and relate to different social actors and groups.

In terms of the linguistic turn of terrorism studies (Straun 2009) and terrorist threat assessment (see, e.g., Turner and Gelles 2003), a critical issue in investigating terrorist communication in future studies is to treat it as a social semiotic activity (see, e.g., Halliday and Hasan 1985; van Leeuwen 2008). If we want to understand co-constructed identities and ideological struggle, we need systematic ways of accounting for the role of language in contested, interpersonal meanings, values and thus relationships – an issue this study contributed to. Attitudinal stances and underlying values, realizable by lexicogrammatical patterns (Lukin 2019, 75) of attitude, were also found to play important roles in the rhetoric of bin Laden in terms of damaging the social identities of opponents and maintaining/or negotiating enacted attitudes with (skeptical) audiences.

Terrorist discourses of violence are a global sociopolitical and security problem which needs be tackled from new perspectives. This study has contributed to showing how linguistic evidence of kinds of identities and characteristic functional patterns of attitude could be investigated, yielding insights into how concerned authorities may better understand, suspect and/or counter (potential) aggression based on evaluative semantics-evidence. This study further adds to protocols of action and tools available to study the language of discourses of violence and extract patterns of meaning that may arise therein. To that end, we have emphasized the value of investigating language on both syntagmatic and paradigmatic axes, with a focus on a functional linguistic account of relevant features.

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Appendix 1. Frequent expressions of JUDGEMENT underlying personal and relational identity

Attitudinal		
lexis	Judgement	Attitudinal target
Fight	– P (pos)	– act performed by the author's group
	– p	– act performed by the US troops
Kill	– P (pos)	– act performed by the author's group
	– P	– act performed by the US and US allies
Jihad	+ P	– act performed by the author's group
Support	+ P	– act by whoever to the side of (i.e. with) America; act by whoever to the side of 'infidel' parties; act by the US towards Israel
		– act by the author's group
Enemy	– P	– America; crusader
injust(ice)/ unjust	– P	– American act/ campaign in Iraq; war on Iraq; the American Israeli coalition against people in Palestine and Lebanon; regimes in Muslim world; US-led coalition act
Bombing	– P	– act performed by the US and US allies
Mujahid	+ P	– people of Iraq; doctor Ayman al-Zawahiri; people of Afghanistan; author's group-fighters
Defend/ defence	+ P	– acts performed by the author's group
		– acts performed by the Americans
Infidel(ity)	– P	– heads of Islamic states; parties such as the Arab Socialist Ba'th and Socialists in Baghdad or Aden; non-Muslim camp fighting against Muslims; everyone who cooperates with the United States or its off-shoots
		– act of war waged by America and its allies; forces of the new Jewish Crusade
Crusade(r)	– P	– US forces and their allies
		– the act/war by the US
		– Bush the senior; Bush the junior

Attitudinal		
lexis	Judgement	Attitudinal target
Traitor	– P	– act of Prince Abdullah bin Abdelaziz (of Saudi Arabia) – Iraq and Arab governments – the toppled and new president of Iraq – all Arab governments – any government in the region formed by the United States – Arab rulers
Destroy	– P (pos) – P	– act performed by al-Qaeda – act performed by Israel supported by the US – act performed by the US
Hypocrisy/ hypocrite	– P	– US led-forces – rulers of Arab countries
Oppress(or)	– P	– Americans – Arab rulers
Innocent	+ N	– women and children affected
Lose/loss	– P	– America, the White House administration, and Israel
Tyrant/ tyranny	– P	– the new Jewish crusade forces; Bush; American Israeli coalition; America – Arab rulers
Free	+ T	– the author's group; people of Iraq
Bomb/ bombardment	– P	– act performed by the Americans and their allies
Evil	– P	– alliance against al-Qaeda's fighters – forces against the Muslim world – elected US officials
Faithful	+ T	– mujahidin; Afghan people; the commander Mulla Mohammad Omar
Attack(s)/ed/ ing)	– P (pos) – P	– act performed by the author's group – act performed by the Americans
Invade	– P	– act performed by the Americans forces; act performed by Israel
Liar/lie(s)	– P	– US administration; America – whoever does not fight against US coalition
Punish(ment)	– P	– act performed by the author's group
Aggression	– P	– act performed by the American
Apostate/ apostasy	– P	– governments of invaders – whoever helped America, and whoever cooperates with the United States or its off-shoots – ruling regimes in Muslim world
Gang	– P	– US administration; the White House officials
Military	– P	– half of the regimes ruling Arab countries – US presence in the land of the Two Holy Mosques
Strike	– P	– act performed by al-Qaeda
Traitor	– P	– Arab rulers or regimes; Arab governments cooperating with the US; any Muslim country's government formed by America

Attitudinal		
lexis	Judgement	Attitudinal target
(en)slave	– P	– act by Arab ruling regimes towards their peoples – act by America towards ruling regimes – act by American officials towards the US people
Humiliation	– P	– act by Americans and Arab rulers against Muslims
Hero(ic)	+ N	– who killed King Abdullah bin al-Hussein – fighting Afghan people – Mujahidin in Iraq – acts by Palestinian people – the Jihadi who killed Anwar al-Sadat
Steadfast	+ T	– mujahidin

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